

| By S. Prasannarajan |

Cruising at 400 mph at an altitude of more than 30,000 ft is not the kind of travel that has brought him so far, even if the clouds passing by the windows of the Hawker executive jet whisper celestial messages to this passenger who has always known how to communicate with gods. As the long distance charioteer of Indian politics, he had journeyed across the disputed sites of mythology and the archival debris of civilisation, mobilising the aggrieved Hindu against the state that denied him his deities. He was the nationalist on wheels who converted the resentment of religion into a historic vote that would give India its first right-wing government, though not exactly a Ram Rajya—praise the Lord. But then it was not *his* government; the glory was entirely monopolised by a man who preferred stillness to motion, pause to the prosaic. It was a short-lived romance; the shining stupidity of a slogan

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